

MILL HOUSE NEIGHBOURHOOD HOUSE

STRATEGIC PLAN 2025-2030

(DRAFT)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Mill House Neighbourhood House is a community hub under the governance of Goldfields Employment and Learning Centre Inc (GELC). Mill House has evolved from an employment services facility to a Neighbourhood House Model, focusing on Community development, social inclusion, and life skills.

VISION AND OBJECTIVES

Mill House aims to enrich the local community by fostering social connectedness, promoting healthy lifestyles, and providing learning and recreational opportunities in an inclusive, safe, and welcoming environment. The Strategic Plan for 2025-2030 outlines the following key goals.

- (1) **Governance:** Ensure quality governance practices and policies, with a focus on compliance, risk management, financial oversight, and strategic direction.
- (2) **Practice:** Engage participants in activities that support positive health and wellbeing, responding to community needs and interests.
- (3) **Youth-engagement:** Create a thriving environment for young people to lead, belong, and build their future through youth-led governance and inclusive access.
- (4) **Conference hall and Community data centre:** Develop a dynamic hub for connection, collaboration, and digital empowerment.
- (5) **Connections:** Build effective partnerships with community, network, government, and funders to achieve mutually beneficial community outcomes.

Key Actions and Performance Indicators

- Review and update governance policies and procedures.
- Launch new programs based on community feedback.
- Establish a Youth Advisory Committee and increase youth participation in programs.
- Upgrade the conference hall and establish a community data centre.
- Increase active partnership agreements and host partnership events.

Monitoring and Evaluation

The progress towards achieving the strategic plan goals will be reported annually at the Annual General Meeting. Quarterly reviews will be conducted to track and evaluate the implementation of the strategic plan.

Conclusion

Mill House Neighbourhood House is committed to fostering a resilient and inclusive community through adaptive reuse, social innovation, and responsive programming. The strategic plan for 2025-2030 sets a clear roadmap for achieving these goals and enhancing the wellbeing of the Central Goldfields region.

INTRODUCTION

Mill House Neighbourhood House, located at 88-90 Burke Street, Maryborough Vic, is a place-based community hub, operating under the governance of **Goldfields Employment and Learning Centre Inc. (GELC)**. It serves as a catalyst for social inclusion, lifelong learning, and community resilience in the Central Goldfields region. Mill House stands as a testament to adaptive reuse, social innovation, and community resilience in regional Victoria.

Originally established in **1993** within the repurposed **Maryborough Knitting Mills Facility**. Mill House has evolved through several iterations – including Skill Share, Maryborough Regional Education and Training Services Inc, and Goldfields Employment and Learning Centre. Following the wind-down of formal training operations in 2005, the facility transitioned into a **Neighbourhood House Model**, gradually shifting focus from employment services to **community development, social inclusion, and life skills**. By the early 2010s, it was locally known as **Mill House**, and in **2021**, the name **Mill House Neighbourhood House** was formerly registered under **Goldfields Employment and Learning Centre Inc, (GELC)**. This legacy of adaptive reuse and vocational heritage informs its current role as a responsive, trauma-informed, and inclusive space for community engagement. **Mill House Neighbourhood House** is an active member of **RANCH- (Regional Association of Neighbourhood and Community Houses)**, a collaborative network supporting 33 houses – 29 funded and 4 unfunded – across six local government areas in Central Victoria. It's listed under the **Goldfield's Cluster**, which includes several houses in the Central Goldfields Shire. This affiliation strengthens our capacity for regional partnerships, shared training, and coordinated service delivery.

Our main objectives are to enrich our local community by developing social connectedness, promoting healthy lifestyles and providing opportunities of learning, recreation and support for any age and any ability within an inclusive, safe and welcoming environment. We are responsive to community needs and building resilience. We provide a venue that supports, engages, connects and excites our community through lifelong learning, social activities and responding to community needs while delivering intangible benefits such as community pride and sense of belonging, leadership development, community voice through advocacy and increased personal independence.

GOVERNANCE AND OPERATIONAL ADMINISTRATION

The governance structure of Mill House Neighbourhood House is built around community-led principles and formal oversight mechanisms.

Committee of Management

A volunteer Committee of Management (CoM) is the primary governance body responsible for overseeing the strategic direction, compliance, and accountability of Mill House Neighbourhood House. The Committee of Management is responsible for five key governance domains.

(1) Operational framework.

-It establishes and maintains policies, delegation of authority, and employee management systems.

(2) Compliance Management.

-It ensures that Mill House meets legal, regulatory, and funding bodies requirements.

(3) Risk Management.

-Committee of Management oversees safety, Child protection, and organisational risk audits.

(4) Financial oversight.

-Committee of Management monitors budgets, funding, and financial performance.

(5) Strategic direction.

-Committee of Management guides long-term planning, Community engagement, and program development.

STAFF

Department of Families, Fairness and Housing (DFFH) funds the employment of the Mill House Neighbourhood House Coordinator.

The Coordinator/Manager works closely with the Committee of Management.

The Coordinator/Manager is responsible for:

(1) Strategic and Operational leadership

-Implements strategic plans -translates CoM's strategic direction into actionable programs and services.

- Ensures all activities align with organisational policies, funding guidelines, and legal obligations.

- Manage program budgets, apply for grants, and monitor financial sustainability.

(2) Community Engagement and Program development

- Design and deliver programs based on community consultation and local priorities.

- Create safe and welcoming spaces for people of all backgrounds.

- Recruit, train and support volunteers to deliver programs and events.

(3) Monitoring and Reporting

- Track participation, outcomes, and feedback to inform continuous improvement.

- Provide regular updates to CoM, funding bodies, and community partners.

(4) Support the Committee of Management

- Acts as the operational link between governance and service delivery.

- Multi-Agency Partnerships (build relationships with local services, schools, councils, and networks) to enhance program reach.

(5) Capacity building and leadership

- Lead and support facilitators and staff.

- Professional development (Promote trauma-informed, ethical, and culturally safe practice across all activities).

Volunteers

- A large team of volunteers supports programming, events, and administrative tasks, reflecting the house's community driven ethos.

Table chart: Roles and Responsibilities

COMMITTEE OF MANAGEMENT	COORDINATOR/MANAGER
Strategic planning and oversight	Day-to-day operations and program delivery
Policy developments and review	Implementation of policies and procedures
Financial oversight and budgeting	Budget execution and reporting
Risk and compliance monitoring	Operational risk management and audits
Staff and volunteer governance	Staff supervision and volunteer coordination
External partnership and Advocacy	Community engagement and stakeholder liaison

FUNDING

*State Government Support:

-Core funding comes from DFFH for coordination and operations.

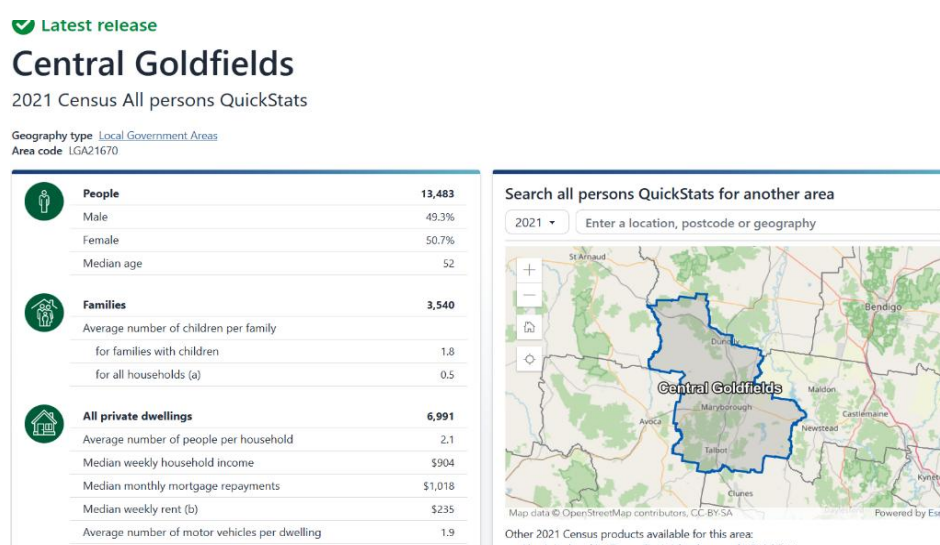
*Grants and Fundraising:

-Mill House Neighbourhood House applies for additional funding through various government and community grants and hosts social fundraising events to support its programs.

DEMOGRAPHIC SUMMARY

Mill House Neighbourhood House is accessed by people from across the broader Goldfields region, not just locals. Mill House attracts participants from surrounding towns like Dunolly, Carisbrook, Talbot, Bealiba, Maldon, Clunes, Avoca, Newstead, and Amphitheatre.

Snapshot from ABS



PROGRAM

Mill House Neighbourhood House offers a rich mix of programs designed to foster creativity, connection, and practical skills across the community.

(1) Creative Arts and Expression

-Art group, Drawing, Embroidery, writing groups, scrap booking, crochet, book club, stamp club, Bridge, dungeons and dragons.

(2) Digital literacy and safety

-Tech skills workshops.

(3) Community Engagement and Volunteering

-Volunteering opportunities – Mill House actively invites locals to contribute their time and skills, helping build a stronger, more inclusive community.

(4) Life skills and Employment

- Mill House partners with APM, AXIS and Personnel Group who offer employment services.

(5) Social Connection and Events

- Food market, community lunch, cooking class.

- Informal events that bring people together to connect, celebrate, and support one another.

- Our Conference Hall offers services to other community organisations, not-for profit organisations, and community members at a low fee.

*Mill House Neighbourhood House also adapts its offerings based on community interest – so if there's a gap or emerging need, we co-create new groups or activities. We are a strong model of responsive, inclusive practice for partnership, program benchmarking or regional collaboration.

CONTEXT FOR THIS STRATEGIC PLAN

The strategic planning process for Mill House Neighbourhood House has been shaped through a collaborative, multi-layered approach that reflects both internal transition and external sector dynamics. This context outlines the foundational inputs, stakeholder engagement, and strategic considerations that inform the direction of the organisation over the coming planning cycle.

From January 2025, the Committee of Management convened a series of planning meetings to review governance structures, operational priorities, and future sustainability. These sessions were enriched by contributions from both the **outgoing Coordinator/manager**, who provided continuity and historical insight, and **the newly appointed acting coordinator/manager**, whose fresh perspective helped align the organisation with emerging community needs and sector trends.

Mill House actively engaged with the **Investing in Rural Community Futures (IRCF)** initiative led-by the **Foundation for Rural Regional Renewal (FRRR)**. Participation in the Maryborough regional workshops and roadmap development process enabled Mill House to align its strategic priorities with the IRCF's four pillars: **Strengthening leadership and governance (People), enhancing planning and Advocacy (Strategy), improving operational infrastructure and digital capability (Systems), and exploring shared services and resource pooling (Efficiencies)**. This alignment ensures that Mill House's strategic direction is responsive to regional priorities and positioned for collaborative impact.

A critical strategic focus has emerged around **youth engagement**, particularly in response to the temporary closure of the Central Goldfields Shire Youth Engagement Hub for renovations. This closure created a significant gap in youth-focused programming and safe spaces. Mill House has responded proactively by embedding youth engagement into its strategic priorities, consulting with young people and partner organisations, and co-designing inclusive, trauma-informed initiatives that promote leadership, digital inclusion, and wellbeing. These positions Mill House as a regional anchor for youth inclusion and innovation during a period of transition.

To support strategic visioning, a dedicated **SOAR Committee (Strengths, Opportunities, Aspirations, Results)** was established. The committee facilitated internal review and reflective analysis, synthesising organisational data, sector benchmarks, and community feedback to identify key leverage points for growth and resilience. Their work helped clarify Mill House's aspirations and measurable outcomes for the next planning cycle.

The strategic plan has also been shaped by extensive stakeholder engagement. Staff and volunteers contributed operational insights that informed service priorities. Program users and participants shared lived experiences that guided accessibility and inclusion goals. Local stakeholders and partner organisations highlighted opportunities for collaboration and innovation, while broader community input – gathered through surveys, forums, and informal engagement – ensured that the plan reflects the diverse voices and evolving needs of the community Mill House serves.

Together, these inputs form a robust foundation for Mill House's strategic direction, reinforcing its commitment to trauma-informed, inclusive, and ethical practice; responsive programming; strengthening governance; and sector collaboration.

STRATEGIC PLAN AND ACTION PLAN 2025-2030

1.GOVERNANCE

GOAL: Governance practice and policy is clearly defined and implemented.

OBJECTIVE	ACTION	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	RESPONSIBLE PERSON	YEAR				
				1	2	3	4	5
1.1 Ensure the quality and integrity of governance practice	1.1.1 Review, update, and digitalize all existing policies and procedures, ensuring 100% are accessible via a central member portal by Q3 2026	80% of policies reviewed/ updated	Committee of Management	•		•		•
	1.1.2 Develop and implement a staff and volunteer Satisfaction Survey, achieving a minimum 80% “satisfied/very satisfied” rate on safety and work environment questions by Q2- 2025	Survey Results; Action plan from feedback	Committee of Management	•	•	•	•	•
	1.1.3 Ratify a revised organizational chart with clearly defined roles, responsibilities, and reporting lines for the Committee of Management and the Coordinator/Manager by Q2- 2025	Signed and published organizational chart	Committee of Management	•				
1.2 Ensure policies and procedures are current, consistent and	1.2.1 Develop and implement a system for the regular review of policies and procedures.	Policy review system exists.	Coordinator	•		•		•

available for all members	1.2.2 Develop, review, update and adopt policies and procedures as per the review system as required	Policy and review system exists. Current policies and procedures to be updated as per the review	Coordinator	•		•		•
1.3 Strengthen organisational sustainability through active membership and volunteer participation.	1.3.1 Design and implement a recruitment strategy targeting diverse community cohorts, including outreach, onboarding, and retention.	10% annual increase in active members; 10 new volunteers onboarded	Committee of Management; Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•
	1.3.2 Explore and introduce group membership	2 New group membership approved by Q3 2026	Committee of Management	•	•	•	•	•

2. PRACTICE

GOAL: Participants engage in activities that support positive health and wellbeing.

OBJECTIVE	ACTION	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	RESPONSIBLE PERSON	YEAR				
				1	2	3	4	5
2.1 Respond to the needs and interests of our members and the community	2.1.1 Launch two new programs/services based on member feedback (from annual survey) by Q3- 2026	Launch dates; Participation numbers	Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•
	2.1.2 Maintain a participant retention rate of over 60% across all core programs for each quarter	Program attendance records; Return participant rates	Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•
	2.1.3 Achieve an average satisfaction score of 4.5/5 or higher on post activity feedback forms throughout the year	Feedback form data	Coordinator/ Committee of Management	•	•	•	•	•

3. YOUTH ENGAGEMENT

VISION: A thriving place where young people lead, belong, and build their future.

GOAL: Youth-led governance, inclusive access, wellbeing, skills for the future.

***OBJECTIVES:** (The objectives are implied through program streams).

OBJECTIVES	ACTION	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	PERSON RESPONSIBLE	YEAR				
				1	2	3	4	5
3.1 Create a governance structure that is responsive to the youth.	3.1.1 Establish a Youth Advisory Committee with at least 10 members by Q2 2025 which will co-design one program stream for Q2-2025 and Q3- 2026	Committee formed; Meeting minutes; program proposal	Youth Coordinator	•				
3.2 Enhance youth participation in programs	3.2.1 Increase youth participation in “Digital futures” and “creative labs” streams by 25% year-on-year by the end of Q2-2025	Participant numbers in target streams	Youth Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•
	3.2.2 Facilitate 4 “Skills for the Future” workshops (e.g., resume clinics, job shadowing) with at least 15 participants	Workshop attendance; post workshop feedback	Youth Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•

	each in Q2-2025 and Q3-2026							
3.3 Increase youth-led participation through tailored volunteer opportunities	3.3.1 Create youth-specific volunteer roles and promote through local schools and networks	5 Youth volunteers engaged annually: two youth-led initiatives	Coordinator; Youth coordinator	•	•	•	•	•

4.CONFERENCE HALL AND COMMUNITY DATA CENTRE

GOAL: To create a dynamic hub where connection, collaboration, and digital empowerment drive social impact.

OBJECTIVE	ACTION	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	RESPONSIBLE PERSON	YEAR				
				1	2	3	4	5
4.1 Upgrade hall; Establish data centre; Promote digital inclusion; Strengthen collaboration	4.1.1 Secure funding and complete the upgrade of the conference hall with hybrid meeting capabilities by Q3 2026	Grant approval; Project completion sign-off.	Committee of Management	•	•			
	4.1.2 Launch phase 1 Community Data Centre (Secure local data storage and access points) by Q3 2026	Infrastructure is operational; Number of user logins.	Committee of Management	•	•			

	4.1.3 Partner with a local digital literacy NGO to offer 3 beginner digital skills courses for underserved groups in Q2-2025	Partnership agreement; Course attendance numbers	Committee of Management/ Coordinator	•	•			•
4.2 Activate the space through member-led programs and digital inclusion initiatives.	4.2.1 Encourage members and volunteers to initiate and lead hall activities and digital sessions.	5 member-led programs annually; Recruit volunteers to lead digital inclusion sessions and hall activities; 80% utilisation of hall and data centre.	Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•

5.CONNECTIONS:

GOAL: Our partnerships achieve mutually beneficial community development outcomes.

OBJECTIVES	ACTION	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	PERSON RESPONSIBLE	YEAR				
				1	2	3	4	5
5.1 Build effective relationships with community, network, government, and funders.	5.1.1 Increase active partnership agreements with local service providers by Q2-2025	Signed partnership MoU's; Joint project plans.	Coordinator/ Committee of Management	•	•	•	•	•
	5.1.2 Host two partnership events per year (e.g., morning tea, open day) with key local and state representatives to showcase impact.	Event attendance lists; Follow-up actions	Committee of Management	•	•	•	•	•
	5.1.3 Submit at least five funding applications to diverse bodies (government, trust, corporate) in Q2-2025	Number of applications submitted; Success rate.	Coordinator	•	•	•	•	•

MONITORING AND EVALUATION

FOCUS	GOAL	PERFORMANCE MEASURE	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATOR	DATA SOURCE
GOVERNANCE	Governance practice and policy are clearly defined and implemented.	• Achievement of task. • 80% of “satisfaction rate”	• Strategic plan actions commenced and completed	• Strategic plan • Volunteer satisfaction
PRACTICE	Participants engage in activities that support positive health and wellbeing.	• Increase in participation numbers. • New programs commenced	• New activities and diversification of programs. • Number of participants	• Records of attendance • Participants annual survey
YOUTH ENGAGEMENT	Youth-led governance, inclusive access, wellbeing, skills for the future.	• Committee has been voted in and is operational	• Increase in participation of the youth. • Workshop attendance	• Program streams • Action plans
CONFERENCE HALL AND COMMUNITY DATA CENTRE	To create a dynamic hub where connection, collaboration, and digital empowerment drive social impact.	• Grant approval • Completion sign-off.	• Infrastructure is operational	• Inventory records • Action plans
CONNECTIONS	Our partnerships achieve mutually beneficial community development outcomes	• Signed partnership agreements and MoU's	• Joint project plans • Event attendance	• Register of agreements

REPORTING

The Committee of Management reports annually to the members at the Annual General Meeting. The progress towards achieving the strategic plan goals will be reported annually at Mill House Neighbourhood House at the Annual General Meeting.

A quarterly “track and trace” review meeting will be conducted where the responsible officer’s/officials would report back to the Committee of Management. The Committee of Management may appoint sub-committees to handle various pillars of the plan as primary owners. Such sub-committees when formed, would report back to the Committee of Management quarterly. Progress reports from the youth coordinator and the Mill House Neighbourhood House Coordinator/Manager will be forwarded quarterly to the Committee of Management.

SWOT Analysis

STRENGTHS •Volunteers •Central location •Friendly atmosphere •Variety of activities •Low operating cost •Ample indoor/outdoor space •Established reputation	OPPORTUNITIES •Use of social media and other marketing tools. •Use of kitchen facilities •Reach out to broader community •Youth hub for the region •Availability of rooms for programs/hire/rent •Mutually beneficial partnerships •Growth in digital connectivity needs •Grants for tech updates •Post Covid desire for connection •Council focus on resilience •High demand for youth programs
WEAKNESSES •Parking •Wheelchair accessibility •Smart technology/phone line •Supports a small community demography •Limited marketing •Reliance on short term funding •Specific skills gap	THREATS •Breakdown of relationships and micromanagement •Inability to provide an engaging program to community •Marketing and promotion •Inability to attract a variety of skill share volunteers •Competing organisations •Funding cuts •Economic pressures on families •Volunteer burnout

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